Design System and Interaction Specification

AICTE Approval Workflow Portal

Version: 1.0 · **Status:** Design handoff · **Date:** 22 October 2026

1. Design direction

Use an Apple-inspired level of polish—consistent spacing, restrained motion, clear hierarchy and careful detail—without copying Apple's product UI. The portal should feel like a modern, trustworthy administrative tool: **medium visual richness, not bare-minimum and not decorative/maximal**.

Priorities in order:

1. Clarity and task completion.
2. Trust, accessibility and legibility.
3. Consistent interaction patterns.
4. Subtle visual polish.
5. Animation only when it explains state or provides feedback.

2. Colour system

Use a light theme by default. Recommended initial palette is **Emerald + warm white**; this can be changed as a product decision without changing component semantics.

- Primary: `#176B5B` — primary buttons, active navigation and key brand elements.
- Primary hover: `#125548` — hover/pressed state.
- Main background: `#F6F8F5`.
- Surface/card: `#FFFFFF`.
- Border: `#DDE4DF`.
- Main text: `#17211D`.
- Secondary text: `#5D6963`.
- Link/focus accent: `#236B9A` or another tested accessible blue.
- Success: `#168568`.
- Warning: `#946200` with a pale warning surface.
- Error/overdue: `#B42318` with a pale error surface.
- Neutral/info: `#52616B`.

Do not use primary green as the only signal of success. Every status needs a text label and, where useful, an icon. Verify contrast for actual text/background combinations against WCAG AA targets; adjust shades if needed.

3. Typography and spacing

- Use Inter or a similar legible sans-serif.
- Page title: approximately 24–30 px, medium/semibold.
- Section heading: 16–20 px, semibold.
- Body: 14–16 px; table text should remain readable.

- Metadata/helper text: generally 12–13 px, not for essential instructions.
- Use an 8 px spacing scale (4 px for tight inline gaps).
- Main content max width should fit dense tables; avoid overly narrow dashboard columns.
- Cards: 10–14 px radius, 1 px border, minimal shadow.
- Buttons: consistent height and clear labels; primary action should be obvious.
- Use Lucide-style line icons consistently. Avoid mixing icon packs.

4. Layout

Public landing page

- Simple top navigation with product name, short explanation and sign-in action.
- Hero message explaining approval workflow + compliance in plain language.
- Three or four capability blocks: approval workflow, document pre-check, compliance tracking, alerts/audit.
- Clear “Sign in” CTA.
- Footer note: student prototype/demo unless formally authorised; not an official AICTE service.
- No fake official seals, logos or claims of government endorsement.

Authenticated application

- Desktop: left navigation sidebar, top bar with page title/breadcrumbs, notifications and user menu.
- Content area: page title, concise summary, primary action, then filters/table/cards.
- Sidebar can collapse, but preserve clear labels or tooltips.
- Tables should prioritise institution, reference ID, stage/status, next action, responsible party and due date.
- Use sticky table headers only when useful.
- Forms should group related fields and clearly distinguish required/optional inputs.
- Show unsaved changes and destructive actions explicitly.

Three role dashboards

1. **Institution dashboard:** applications, returned cases, pre-check results, compliance calendar, document renewals, notifications and submission history.
2. **AICTE officer dashboard:** assigned queue, scrutiny work, deficiency resolution, EVC/compliance tasks according to permission, upcoming/overdue actions and case timeline.
3. **AICTE administrator dashboard:** authorised regional/national overview, stage ageing, workload, EVC status, obligations/document validity, escalations, reports and configuration.

College/university can share a dashboard shell but must have data and actions scoped to actual authorisation.

5. Status patterns

Use consistent labels:

- Draft
- Submitted
- Under scrutiny
- Returned for correction
- Correction submitted
- Awaiting verification

- Ready for next stage
- EVC required / EVC scheduled / EVC completed
- Compliance due / Evidence submitted / Verified / Overdue
- Completed / Closed

Actual labels must reflect the configured process. Don't imply all routes use all stages. Avoid colour-only status communication.

6. Motion and animation rules

Motion should be purposeful, brief and restrained. Suggested durations are starting points and should be tested:

- Page/content transition: opacity fade plus 4–8 px vertical movement, 150–220 ms, once on navigation.
- Button hover/press: colour/opacity change, 100–160 ms; optional 1 px press response.
- Interactive card hover: border/shadow change and at most 1–2 px lift, 120–180 ms. Do not make non-interactive cards appear clickable.
- Modal/drawer: fade and 6–10 px movement or subtle scale from 98% to 100%, 160–220 ms.
- Upload: progress bar with real progress where available; otherwise use an indeterminate spinner. On completion, show a brief checkmark/state change.
- Workflow step update: highlight the changed step for about 500–800 ms; do not animate the whole graph continuously.
- Notification: fade/slide in briefly; no shaking or repeated flashing.
- AI document check: show truthful step states such as “Reading file”, “Checking required fields”, “Comparing configured rules”. Only show steps actually performed. Use skeletons for loading content if helpful.
- Charts: animate once on first render only if it doesn't slow reading; respect reduced-motion.
- Avoid parallax, autoplay video, animated gradient backgrounds, floating decoration, endless pulses, bouncing icons, confetti for routine actions, and animated counters that misrepresent real data.

Reduced motion and accessibility

- Honour `prefers-reduced-motion: reduce`; remove nonessential transforms and transitions.
- Motion must never be the only indication of a status change.
- Maintain visible keyboard focus, keyboard-operable controls, correct semantic labels and accessible live announcements for upload/validation outcomes.
- Do not move focus unexpectedly during transitions.

7. Interaction feedback

Every action needs an outcome:

- Save: saved state or clear failure/retry.
- Upload: progress, accepted/rejected state and reason.
- Pre-check: findings, extraction limitations and rerun option.
- Submit: confirmation and new reference/status.
- Return for correction: required reason and recorded deficiency.
- Verify evidence: explicit verified/rejected/needs-more-information status and officer identity/time.
- Escalation: recipient and delivery/status log.
- Invalid transition: explain which prerequisite or permission is missing.

8. Responsive behaviour

- Desktop is the main target for officer/admin work.
- Tablet layouts should preserve essential table actions and filtering.
- On narrow screens, turn tables into structured cards or allow safe horizontal scrolling; don't hide critical deadlines or status.
- Keep primary actions visible without making the interface crowded.

9. Visual QA checklist

- Consistent spacing, typography, borders, radii and icon style.
- No decorative animation that distracts from case processing.
- Statuses use text plus colour/icon.
- Keyboard focus is visible.
- Reduced-motion setting works.
- Contrast is tested, including muted text and badges.
- Loading, empty, error, permission-denied and success states exist.
- Sample/demo data is labelled and no fake official branding is used.